

during which Ruddy developed myopia and had his first breakdown. The family was reunited when 16-year-old Ruddy, already writing reams of verse and cocksure of his literary talents, took up his first job as Assistant Editor of *The Pioneer* in Lahore.

Kipling's role at *The Pioneer* and later at *The Civil and Military Gazette* taught him the discipline and rigorous enquiry that lent his prose the quality of fact even though it was fiction. As newspapers in those days carried literature as well as news, they also provided the platform for Ruddy to establish himself as a poet and author. Ruddy worked long hours, his white clothes spattered in ink, throwing paperweights at anyone who interrupted him.

He quarrelled with his seniors at the local club, and was kicked down the stairs on at least one occasion. His mood swings, which Allen believes were due to bi-polar disorder, were intense. Opium cocktails got him through the "night terrors" of the hot weather. He also took to walking the streets of the old city of Lahore late at night, "digging up" opium dens and visiting courtesans. Here he found a world like the Arabian nights and became convinced that, under the superstructure of the Raj, ran "wholly untouched and unaffected the life of the people of the land".

Although both his parents were artistic, they were conventional, and Allen believes Ruddy came into his own when he put aside their prejudices to penetrate Indian life—a life that thrilled and fascinated him—more deeply. He revelled in the life of lesser mortals—whether the British tommy in India or the company of the Afghan horse trader who re-appeared in *Kim* as Mahboob Ali. When he saw that the Raj had done nothing to improve the lot of the Indian peasant, he didn't hesitate in expressing his opinion in the verse: "His speech is of mortgaged bedding/ On his kine he borrows yet/ At his heart is his daughter's wedding/ And his eyes foreknowledge debt/ He eats and hath indigestion/ He toils and he may not stop/ His life is a long-drawn question/ Between a crop and a crop."

In short, his East did meet his West, but to discover on what terms you have to read this book. ■



SAURABH SINGH

Karachi Chronicles

An engaging tale of an independent-minded single woman in Pakistan's patriarchal society regulated by Islamic moral police



TUNNEL VISION
by SHANDANA MINHAS
India Ink
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 288

■ **By Bunny Suraiya**

Books set in Pakistan, written by Pakistani writers, are always of great interest to Indian readers, if only for the sense of schadenfreude they excite in us. To read of a place that is not only as dirty and corrupt as India, but is additionally plagued by the pervasive diktats of a fundamental religiosity, provokes a perverse feel-good sensation. Shandana Minhas pulls no punches in her gutsy description of the oppressive nature of Pakistani society, made worse by the Islamic moral policing that allows, for example, cops to demand marriage certificates from couples driving together or to beat up male university students for the "offence" of sitting at a desk adjoining that of a female classmate. The story is great; the format of telling not so felicitous.

Having chosen to write in the first person, Minhas has to fall back on a hackneyed literary device: an out-of-body experience caused by a car crash in the first chapter, which enables the "spirit" of the protagonist, 31-year-old

Ayesha Siddiqui, to hover over her comatose body and listen in on conversations conducted over it. Minhas is smart enough to figure out the arbitrary nature of this fly-on-the-wall style of narrative, and tries to integrate it into the story by sporadically introducing it as a metaphor for Ayesha's alienation, but it doesn't quite work—a sudden, distracting interjection of angst in an otherwise racy tale of what it is to be an independent-minded single woman in Pakistan's patriarchal society, complete with the thought police laying down absurd, yet terrifying codes of conduct.

Minhas's characters are completely real. Ayesha is smart and sassy, with an irreverent sense of humour. Her mother, an upper-class refugee from Hyderabad, India, is frighteningly psychotic. Her father, the son of illiterate peasants from Bihar, is adored by his daughter and wife, who compete unwholesomely for his love, but are unable to fathom the murky secret that will take him from them. Her younger brother is the typically self-obsessed child who renders life hideous at home. These and other personae—the boyfriends, the predatory bosses, the extended family of uncles and aunts—enliven the 'tunnel vision' that the reader willingly shares with Ayesha, making for an engaging read. ■